

If you have followed last month's Fasttrack along with this month's, you pretty much know all there is to know about the Apple ecosystem by now - from devices to software to services and all else there is to it. But it is one thing to look at an ecosystem from the inside and a completely different ballgame to evaluate it in comparison to other ecosystems in the market. And there sure are some pretty strong contenders when it comes to that. Google has its own rich ecosystem comparable to Apple's and Microsoft has been building their's for ages. And on almost every front, each one of these competitors has something to offer. How well do they do it? Let's find out.

Productivity

Office Productivity

- Apple - iWork

When it comes to features, iWork does take a backseat to Microsoft Office. As compared to Office 365, it does not offer cross platform support that well beyond the Apple Ecosystem. Even within the ecosystem, the experience does vary between macOS, iOS and iCloud. For instance, even though files created with iWork do open on all these platforms, results might not always look the same. And iWork isn't exactly great at retaining other file formats – although Apple is upfront about this.



Beyond the ecosystem, the experience is greatly limited. Windows or PC users are limited to using iWork via iCloud at www.icloud.com. When it comes to Android users, there's no way to use iWork as Chrome, Opera, Firefox and other browsers are not supported. Overall, iWork is a good choice if you're getting it bundled with your Mac purchase or you are tied into the Apple ecosystem. Beyond that, Microsoft is better at this.

- Google - Google Docs/G Suite

With Google Drive behind it and Google's mastery of collaborative document editing, the G Suite offers a comprehensive office productivity solution that can take care of most of your document needs.



That being said, it is true that the cloud based offering does lack some advanced features that dedicated offline counterparts can offer, even more so at the app level. But for everyday use at an individual level, the G Suite is definitely the most value for money alternative – it's free!